Red Jasper

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26573011.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Princess Alliance (She-Ra) - Character, Mermista (She-Ra), Magicat Queen (She-Ra)

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Red Jasper

by lologoblens

Summary

Five years after the war, new information tells the Princess Alliance that there is another runestone on Etheria. Lost to time and war it has been all but forgotten for many years. Now it's up to the Best Friend Squad to recover the runestone and uncover the mysteries it's shrouded in.

The Lost Runestone

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The pounding at the door is relentless and somehow cheery. As far as Catra is concerned there's really no question over who it could be. She pulls herself out of bed and trudges to the door, wrenching it open. "Scorp, what the hell are you doing here?"

"Wildcat! Hey, hey! I think the real question is what are *you* doing here?" Scorpia claps her on the shoulder and in her sleepy state it almost knocks her to the ground. Her tail thrashes slightly in irritation, she might be a little grumpy at having been woken up.

"Well I'm not supposed to be on my honeymoon right now so…no, not really."

"Perfuma and I are still leaving today! We just wanted to get in one last Alliance meeting in before we go. Which, by the way, is where I think you're supposed to be right now. Adora was gonna come looking for you but I persuaded her to let me do the honors. But seriously, everyone is waiting, so we gotta go."

Catra rolls her eyes, at the message and the enthusiasm, but relents. She pulls a sweater on over the tank top she'd stolen from Adora and closes the door behind her. "Literally why would you postpone your honeymoon for this? It's not like there's anything to talk about at these stupid meetings anymore. I wasn't even gonna go until *someone* decided to wake me up."

"Aw, come on Wildcat! Sure, there is. If nothing else, it gives everyone an opportunity to catch up."

"Catch up? Scorp, everyone was at your wedding like, three days ago."

"Geez, wasn't that a great day? Perfuma really looked like an angel. And that caterer Entrapta recommended knocked it out of the park with those tiny, little cupcakes."

"Those were really good, I think Adora ate her weight in those stupid things." Catra softens at the reminder of Scorpia's wedding day. It was gooey and romantic and almost too much. It also made Catra cry like a baby to see her best friend so happy. She deserved it more than anyone after everything she went through, after everything *Catra* had put her through, during the war. It had been an honor to stand as her witness, though she couldn't say she loved being on display in front of all those people.

She wondered passively if that's the sort of thing Adora imagines for their future wedding. Or if, like Catra, she envisions something smaller and more intimate. Maybe just the two of them if she's honest…. She shakes herself out of her reverie as they approach the council room and tunes into what Scorpia is saying again.

"…and apparently there *is* something of substance to discuss this time. Bow and Entrapta had that mission, you know the one, and I think something came of it." Scorpia flings the door open, capturing the attention of every princess and non-princess in the room.

"Well, well, well." Glimmer drawls from her spot at the head of the table. "Look what the cat dragged in."

Catra scoffs and circles the table to drop herself onto Adora's lap. "Pretty rude way to refer to Scorpia there Glitter. Also, you make that joke all the time, and it's never funny."

"I mean, it's a little funny." Adora snickers from behind her. "Also, um hi. Are you just gonna sit there the whole meeting or…?"

"If you're lucky Princess." Catra turns slightly to wink at her, enjoying the way it still manages to fluster her after all this time.

"Catra! This is a meeting, some decorum pl-are you wearing pajamas?" Glimmer looks her up and down, astonished.

Catra just shrugs nonchalant, ignoring the snickering around the table. “Scorpia woke me up from a nap.”

“Cat nap!” Frosta calls from across the table, earning an icy glare from Catra.

“What, couldn’t afford a babysitter Sparkles?”

“I’m sixteen!” Frosta pauses. “And three quarters.”

Catra inspects her nails, already bored of this exchange. “And still making the same dumb jokes you were when I met you. Whatever, Scorpia said this meeting is like, an actual meeting? I take it to mean we have something to discuss other than the colors for who-the-hell-ever is getting married next.”

“Oh! The sage green and faded crimson looked just perfect! Didn’t they sweetie?” Perfuma turns to Scorpia for validation. “Excellent suggestion Catra, you really saved the day.”

“Yeah, pretty sure I said pink and green. Which are basically the only colors you wear, hardly an inspired suggestion.”

Perfuma just shrugs. “Catra, your aura is very clouded this afternoon. Would you like to join me for a meditation after the meeting? I’m sure we have time.” She looks to Scorpia again who nods.

“It’s fine Fuma, I did one this morning. Scorp just got me in the middle of a rem cycle.”

“Listen…” Mermista cuts in. “As truly fascinating as all of this is, some of us have places to be, so can we like, get on with it.”

“Yes!” Glimmer seizes the opportunity to get the meeting back on track. “Thank you Mermista, excellent suggestion. Now, *as I was saying*; Bow and Entrapta picked up a signal coming from an old First One’s ruin up in the Kingdom of Snows. They went out with She Ra and were able to collect an old corroded message. Entrapta, if you will?”

“Right!” Entrapta lifts herself from her chair with her pigtails, keeping her legs crossed, and uses one to extract some weird metal hunk from a pocket. “This was embedded in Light Hope’s operating system. It appears to have been intended to override her mainframe. It was *very* challenging to extract- “

Adora snorts quietly from behind Catra and whispers in her ear. “Yeah, definitely not more challenging then fighting off all the spiders she activated like, four times.”

Catra sniggers and whispers from the corner of her mouth. “I thought Hope wasn’t doing that stuff anymore. Isn’t she out of commission?”

She feels Adora shrug and she snuggles further into her. “Pretty much, something Entrapta did trying to get that disk set off some version of her, I guess. Entrapta thinks it’s just the security system or something. I wasn’t really listening. You know, because; spiders.”

“Well, glad you made it out alive I guess.”

Adora scoffs. “You guess. Like you wouldn’t be lost without me.”

“Shut up.” Catra elbows her and continues, “I’m *trying* to listen here Princess.” And with that tunes back into whatever Entrapta is jabbering about.

“…after several failed tests I think I’ve been able to recover the message! It appears to have been left by the rebellion led by Mara, the previous She Ra. Not by Mara herself, but another leader within the rebellion. And she’s a- well, just wait and see!” She cackles and claps her hands together. “Catra, I think you’ll find this especially interesting. Adora, say the thing!”

Catra raises a brow and turns to look at Adora. She just shrugs back, apparently she hasn’t seen it yet either. “Hello,” She calls out to the hung of metal in the middle of the table. The rest of the Alliance members look on with interest. “we’re Friends of Mara.”

The thing hums and then glows blue, and a hologram bursts forth. The image is distorted and the voice crackles and breaks, but there’s no mistaking what they’re all seeing; there in the center of the table is another magicat. And she’s wearing an ornate crown.

Chapter End Notes

Just finished one story and already back on my bullshit! Woop woop!
Surprised myself by writing something *other* than a modern AU, and I'm excited to explore this world a bit! I also actually *started* with an outline this time, so that's something new and different for me!
Chapters will likely be pretty short, updates *should* be quick!
Thanks for reading!!

Queen of the Magicats

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Squadr-n Grayskull-ull, this is Princess Saz report- for Squadron Halfmoon. The Red Jasper has been destroy-yed. I still have my powers but…I can al-al-already feel them waning. If Mara is right the planet will remain unbalanced and we are safe now. We are safe now. We are-ar-ar- I have to go, Halfmoon will move underground at nightfall. This is Princess Saz, signing off."

The room is so silent you could hear a pin drop, everyone just stares at the center of the room. Catra can feel the moment everyone starts to sneak glances at her out of the corners of their eyes. What? Do they think she knew about this or something? Because she doesn't know who "Princess Saz" is, and she sure as hell didn't know there was, what? And entire Queendom of Magicats at some point?

Finally, Glimmer breaks the silence. "Well obviously we have to investigate this, find this Red Jasper." And with that pronouncement everyone is talking at once, giving their opinions, asking questions no one knows the answers to, even Adora leans so far over Catra that she slips off her lap and onto the adjacent chair. A minute or so later Catra decides she's no longer needed here and slips out of the room.

Catra's favorite direction to go in when she's upset is *up*. Since moving to Brightmoon she's found plenty of spots that fit the bill; the roof, several tall trees in the gardens, the pillar under the Moonstone. Her favorite by far is the weird, empty turret in the east wing. She's pretty sure it's meant to be a lookout post, but no one seems to have used it in centuries until she finds it. Overtime she's cleaned it up and stashed some pillows, blankets and snacks up there. It's her own secret hide out.

Of course, the thing about dating Adora is that she takes the whole "what's mine is yours" thing very seriously. Catra had been able to sneak up here a few times before Adora caught on. Then Catra had stolen one too many pillows from their bed. So now it's still Catra's favorite place to hide, but when she comes up here, she knows the getting found part is inevitable. At least she can usually get Adora to cuddle up here with her for a little bit after she finds her. The snacks help.

She goes there now, ready to resume her nap and wanting to be left alone for as long as possible. She curls up and gets comfortable, but when she closes her eyes all she can see is that stupid hologram. She tries her breathing exercises, tries noting everything she can sense; she sees the stone wall, the duvet she had stolen from Glimmer and Bow's room, her own hand. She smells the fresh air and- Did she ever live in Halfmoon? Are there any other Magicats left? How did *no one* know there was supposed to be another runestone? It obviously didn't work destroying the Red Jasper, does that mean it's irreparable? Why else would they have left it ruined? Assuming anyone could even find it…

She can't stop the spiral, and when she runs out of questions the just become cyclical, tumbling around and around in her brain. So, when Adora finds her she is *not*, in fact, napping. Rather, she is laying in the same position and staring at the same spot on the wall she has been since she got up here. Adora sits by her head, back leaned against the wall, and Catra takes the invitation to use Adora's legs as a pillow.

"Hey." Adora starts softly.

"Hi."

"I'm sorry everyone…we're all just surprised." Catra doesn't say anything, Adora has to know that no one is more surprised than she is. "Do you…how are you?" Catra turns onto her back and just blinks back at her. She has no words. "Right. I know…I know you

didn't *know* but…Catra, do you remember where you came from? We've never really talked about it."

Catra's ears fold back, she shakes her head and blinks away tears that pool in her eyes, they roll over her temples and into her hair. "No," Her voice is hoarse, she barely sounds like herself. "the first thing I remember is you."

"Oh." Neither of them knows what to say in the wake of that truth. Adora starts running her fingers through Catra's hair, recently cut short again for the first time in years.

"We're gonna go look for it, right?" Catra eventually asks.

"Um, yeah Glimmer, Bow and I are gonna do some research and see what we can find, try and figure out where to start. Are you coming?"

Catra nods and closes her eyes. "I think I have to."

They don't say anything else after that, Adora just continues to comb her fingers through Catra's hair until the sun dips below the horizon. They emerge after dinner has finished and forage in the kitchens before retiring for the night. Catra falls asleep in an instant.

The Best Friend Squad wastes no time, Micah agrees to oversee the day to day of Brightmoon in Glimmer's absence so they're free to take whatever time they need. Unfortunately for Catra, that means first thing the next morning they're venturing into the Whispering Woods. It's not that she *hates* the woods, it's more that she thinks maybe they still hate *her* a little bit.

"To be fair, you did freeze them over that one time." Glimmer points out when Catra complains about all the roots shifting to trip her up. She's a *cat* for Mara's sake! She's supposed to be coordinated.

“That wasn’t me, that was Entrapta.” She grits out, watching her feet.

“Sure, but you were her commanding officer. Same difference really.”

“I don’t see how.”

Glimmer opens her mouth to bite back but Bow stays her with a hand on her shoulder. “I don’t think she needs you to explain it Hon.” Glimmer rolls her eyes but drops it and they carry on.

Adora sidles up to Catra. “You know…the Whispering Woods kind of love She Ra.”

“And you’re bragging about this *now* because…”

“I’m not bragging.” At Catra’s doubtful looks she amends, “Okay, maybe a little. But I’m *saying*; you want a lift?”

Catra stops and throws her hands on her hips. “I’m perfectly capable of *walking* Adora. I certainly don’t need an eight-foot-tall warrior princess to get to the library.”

“Well, yeah.” Adora smirks. “But do you really *want* to walk?”

Catra considers her options for a moment, the sighs. “Alright, let’s see She Ra then.”

Adora looks like she’s won something as she raises her arm. “For the Honor of Grayskull!”

The copse of trees they’re in fills with rainbow light and Catra shields her eyes. When she drops her arms, She Ra stands before her and Bow and Glimmer have paused their progression as well. When She Ra hauls Catra onto her back Bow starts laughing and Glimmer gives them a sarcastic look. “Really?”

She Ra shrugs unapologetically. “Come on guys, we’re burning daylight here.”

With She Ra leading the charge they reach the library in no time. Lance is out the door before they're within twenty feet of it. "Bow! Oh, and you brought your friends." He rushes toward them, arms spread for a group hug.

"Honey, who's here?" George ducks out. "Bow! So good to see you son. And the rest of you also, please come-Lance you're going to need to let them go if they're going to come in."

"Right, right of course. Please, follow me. How are you feeling? Does anyone need snacks? Some water? We have tea!"

"We're alright Lance, thank you." Glimmer tells him and Catra wishes she would shut up. Personally, Catra would love a snack. George's cookies are out of this world. It's whatever though, she's not actually hungry.

"We're actually here on Alliance business." Bow's announcement gets some raised eyebrows; it's been a while since the Alliance *had* much business. "We think there's a lost runestone."

Lance gasps dramatically. "*Where?* "

"Well…that's kind of what we're hoping to find out."

"Well get in here and let's get to work. Where shall we start Georgie?"

"Hmm…legends? Princesses? Let's split up. Why don't you three start upstairs and we'll start down here.

They part ways and start looking for anything promising. There's a table in the center of the upstairs with a slowly growing pile of books and scrolls. The subjects range from Princess history to She Ra to urban legends of Etheria. No one seems to be able to find much on the Red Jasper, Saz, Halfmoon or anything related to them. After about two hours of searching Glimmer calls out from a distant aisle of books.

"Bow, what even *is* this?"

Catra hears Bow make his way over and, sounding perplexed, tell her, "I'm not sure…." Curious, Adora and Catra make their way over from their respective corners.

Glimmer has a long scroll unrolled and she and Bow are squinting at it, their noses practically pressed to the paper. "Uh, how is a recipe for stew relevant to what we're looking for here? Getting peckish there Sparkles?" She starts to laugh at her own joke when three heads snap in her direction. "*What?* "

"You can *read* this?" Glimmer demands, thrusting the scroll in her direction.

Catra takes it hesitantly and glances at it briefly before looking around at her friends. "Uh, duh." Registering something from the corner of her eyes she looks back down again. "What the…is this a *mouse* stew, is this a joke or something?"

She catches Adora's eye and her partner looks…wary. "Uh…babe, that's not…"

"Not what?" She snaps, not appreciating being left in the dark.

Adora bites her lip and Bow steps in to save her. "Catra, that isn't written in Etherian. I think it's a dead language or something."

"I…" She cuts her eyes from one face to another, seeing her own uncertainty reflected back. "What? I've been shacking up with She Ra too long and now I can magically read First One's writing or something?"

Adora shakes her head. "No, I can't read that Catra, it's not First Ones."

Catra looks down again and she can read the scroll plain as day. '3 cups stock, 20 cactus needles-brined…' Wait…what? "Who the hell cooks with *cactus needles*."

"Cactus needles?" George's voice from the far end of the aisle startles the foursome. He's looking at Lance with a hand on his

chin. “Isn’t that an old magicat practice?”

“Yes! Wait…Catra, can you *read* that?” Catra nods hesitantly. “Oh Bow, you just make the *best* friends. Here, come with us.” They follow him further back to a section of the library. “Really I’m not sure how that scroll ended up over there. It should be *here* with the rest of the dead languages.”

“Geez, how many dead languages does Etheria *have*?” Glimmer asks him.

“Three! First One’s, the language of a lost tribe of indigenous peoples from the north-east of where the Kingdom of Snows now is, and of course; the Magicats’ language. Also known as just ‘Magi’.”

“Okay…so I can read this because I’m a Magicat then? Wouldn’t I have to *learn* it at some point still?”

“I mean, I didn’t have to learn First One’s writing.” Adora shrugs. “Maybe it’s like that.”

“Yes, very curious.” George muses. “We assumed that had something to do with you being the She Ra, perhaps something about your connection to the runestone. So I really can’t say if this is an innate Magicat knowledge or not. The truth is we don’t know much about the Magicats. They were always a very private people. Then, when the Horde attacked, they took to the underground tunnels Princess Saz had built many years before.”

“Princess Saz!” Glimmer exclaims. “Her message is what brought us here, she was working with Mara! She’s the one who destroyed this supposed runestone.”

“That makes sense! *Of course* the magicats would have had a runestone. There’s actually quite a bit of information about Princess Saz, she was beloved all over Etheria…Oh! Honey-will you get the- “

“Yes, yes. And you can find the rest of- “

“Of course.” Lance wanders off and George turns back to them. “Alright kids, I think we have a lead. Gather all the books here written in Magi and meet us downstairs.”

They do as their told and pile the books in the center of the room on the floor. They sit haphazardly around them and when George and Lance join them, they take the couch.

“Alright,” George begins. “here’s what we know about the Magicats.”

Her drops a few books written in Etherian in front of them. Each one takes a book to study absently as Lance takes over. “Right, so like we said, a very private people. Most of them never bothered to learn Etherian and were generally slow to trust anyone from the world outside of their Queendom. The only time period we have much to go on without a way to translate Magi is Princess Saz’s rule.”

George cuts in. “Yes, you see Saz was not a traditional Queen as far as we can tell. The Queens of the Magicats were chosen, not by a line of succession, but by some other means that remains unclear. They would first become a princess. Then, after their training was complete, they would be coronated as Queen of the Magicats.”

“*However*, by all accounts the queens did seem to mostly follow the same bloodline, much like a traditional line of succession.”

“But Saz wasn’t in that line?” Bow clarifies.

Lance taps is nose and points to his son. “*Exactly* Bow! Saz was actually an orphan, and her time as queen was revolutionary for the Magicats. Trade opened up and there was more cultural exchange than ever before or ever since. However, when Etheria was pulled into Despondos she just…disappeared. No one really knows why, but after her disappearance the Magicats became more separate from the rest of us than ever before.”

“Most historians speculate that they were suspicious of the other Etherian rulers.” George explains. “They may have believed one of them was responsible for Saz’s disappearance. Whether that’s true or not, we have no way to know.”

“A runestone.” Catra interrupts. She looks up from the magicat book she’s been flipping through with wide eyes. “I-It…Saz was chosen by the Red Jasper. That’s how they chose the next queen.”

“So…what happened when it was destroyed? When Saz disappeared? Who was the new queen?” Adora demands of no one in particular.

“Chaos.” Catra whispers. “It must have been…chaos.”

“Okay, so…Saz becomes queen, or a princess I guess, and everyone loves her, she destroys the Red Jasper to try and save the planet then moves her people underground…what? Like, just in case? But then Mara has to move us into Despondos *anyway*, and then Saz just…disappears. So, at this point the magicats are without a queen, without a runestone to choose a new one and, from what that message said, evacuated to this supposed underground. So, I guess the question is…underground *where*?” Glimmer asks the room at large.

Catra can feel Adora’s eyes on her as she asks softly, “And what happened to her people?”

Catra’s voice is nearly inaudible when she looks up to meet Adora’s eyes and adds, “And are there any others left?”

Lance’s eyes are soft and kind when he responds. “That is something we don’t know, I’m so sorry Catra. If there are, they’ve kept to themselves through the war and since. But we do know where their Queendom was. Before the Crimson Waste was the Crimson Waste, Etheria knew that area as Halfmoon; the Magicats' lands.”

“Halfmoon…” Catra tests the word on her tongue. It feels…familiar somehow. She tries to avoid thinking about the implications of

that thought. It doesn’t work very well.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Creating the Magicats' history and mythology has been really fun. Also pretty hard to like, keep my own made up facts straight? Pretty sure it's all in order now!
Thanks so much to everyone reading!! You are appreciated!

Shattered

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Returning to the Crimson Waste always feels a little bit like a homecoming to Catra. She comes with Adora, and sometimes Perfuma, every so often to visit Huntara or just go to the one bar in the area. She just loves it here; the hot, dry air and the way everyone is at least a little rough around the edges-just like her. She can tell Adora is still a little anxious here and it's pretty hilarious. Mostly because rumors of Catra's brief reign, and the single day it took her to get on top, are still whispered about whenever she walks into the room. They're perfectly safe in the Waste.

Admittedly the first time Catra returned was…strange. Memories and what-ifs flooded her mind. She couldn't help but let her mind wander to what life would have been like if she'd listened to Scorpia all those years ago. If she had just *stayed* like Scorpia had suggested, instead of waiting until the heart to do so. She imagines they'd have eventually gotten together, her and Scorpia. She'd known in the moment that it was an option. After all, it was her who walked away the moment before they almost, maybe kissed.

Then she had looked over to Adora. She thought about Scorpia who had, at that time, been about to propose and about the connection she was finally able to make with the Black Garnet. The reminders give her peace, knowing that despite all the pain and atrocities that she caused things had worked out the way they were always meant to.

Realizing she's fallen behind in her musings, Catra drops the train of thought and hurries to catch up. Adora turns to smile at her when she grabs her hand. "Bow?" Adora turns to look back and to her right. "How close are we?"

"Well…" Bow pokes at his tracker pad. "It's not tech, so there's no signal. Going off what the scrolls said though, looks like we just have another mile to go, southwest, and we *should* be in the general area."

Glimmer huffs and whines, "*Why* does it have to be so hot here? And can't we do something about all the *quicksand*? I mean, come on!"

Catra snickers and turns to walk backwards, switching Adora's hand around so she's holding it in her left now. "Aw, what's the matter Sparkles? Not used to working up a sweat on that fancy throne of yours?"

"Catra!" Glimmer bites back. "We literally sparred together two days ago. And you're the one who skipped the last mission."

"Yeah," Catra smirks. "but I won that match."

"Whatever Horde Scum, you only won because you still fight dirty. You know you're on the good side now, right?"

"Please, there's barely even a bad side anymore. Those stupid bandits in the hills hardly count. Someone has to keep things spicy." Adora squeezes her hand once at that and Catra smirks smugly when she looks over and sees that Adora has turned pink from more than just the heat around them.

"Ugh, you're insufferable." Catra just shrugs and turns back around, smirk never slipping.

They walk in companionable silence for another half mile or so. After a little while Adora speaks up. "What if it's there? What if there really is another runestone?" No one answers her so she continues to spiral. "Why didn't anyone ever try to connect to it? And when is the last time someone did? *Can* anyone even connect with it? The heart was able to be activated without it. I would think if there was an entire runestone off line the planet wouldn't balance."

“I’m not sure Adora.” Glimmer answers after a beat of silence. “We’ll just have to see if this thing even exists to start.”

Catra snorts and it earns her a glare from Glimmer. “Oh please, *of course* it exists.”

“Oh, and you would know?”

“First of all, we have that message from Saz. And it’s just obvious, you guys attract weird crap like this all the time. If there’s a legend out there She Ra will prove it to be true. Prove me wrong.” No one has any ammunition to fight her with and she smiles grimly. “Ugh, remember that third planet we went to on the road trip? Those crazy- “

“Yes Catra!” Adora cuts her off. “We all remember the caves, okay? I don’t know how many times I have to apolog- “

Catra furrows her brow and halts, making everyone else stop with her. She interrupts Adora right back. “Hey, hey Adora, that’s not what I was getting at. And sure, I definitely thought we were all gonna die there, but you were right. With magic back there was no telling how long that thing was gonna stay dormant.”

Adora pouts but looks mostly mollified. “Yeah?”

Catra rolls her eyes and keeps walking. “Yeah dummy.”

“Blech!” Glimmer shivers. “That’s still the *grossest* monster we’ve ever dealt with.”

“I dunno…” Bow argues “That swamp thing on the last planet we went to? That was pretty nasty.”

“Okay, sure. The smell didn’t get out of my hair for like, *a week* after that, but that was more of a supernatural phenomenon than a monster.”

“Fair enough.” Bow answers and their comfortable silence resumes for the last quarter mile. “Alright, this should be the spot.”

“Okay, so…” Adora looks around blankly.

“It’s just *sand*, a big field of *sand*.” Glimmer complains.

“I mean, this thing has been lost for how long? And no one ever found it. It’s gotta be buried or hidden or something.” Catra points out.

“Okay, so how do we figure out where it is?”

“Psh, I dunno.” Catra looks to her girlfriend. “Any fancy She Ra tricks Adora?”

Adora scowls and looks around again. “I guess I could try…” She takes a deep breath and then… “For the Honor of Grayskull!”

Catra’s eyes widen; five or so years of this nonsense and she’s still too gay for this. Then again, how does one grow used to the love of their life transforming into an eight-foot-tall warrior princess? Because Catra is very open to hearing suggestions. Adora gets way too much pleasure out of flustering Catra with that rainbow bullshit.

Fully transformed She Ra traces a circle in the sand with her sword. “Getting anything?” Bow prompts.

She Ra scowls and shakes her head; apparently not. Then she takes a few more paces, moving a little further west. She scrunches her face up and suddenly she raises the sword high above her head. She Ra slams the sword into the sand, and it ripples with the force of it, acting like water disturbed by a stone.

The show of power and strength makes Catra’s cheeks heat and she cuts her eyes to Bow and Sparkles to make sure they aren’t looking at her. If Bow gives her heart eyes and calls her “cute” *one more time*…. And if she never has to see Glimmer give her that knowing smirk again it’ll *still* be too soon. Luckily, they’re just as in awe as she is, and she turns back to the scene before her.

The ripples in the sand die down and left behind is a wide crater, not particularly deep but plenty vast. And there, lying in the bottom just as the stupid scrolls Lance had been gushing about said, were fragments of a large stone. They are a deep, vibrant red with dynamic stripes running irregularly through the stone. The sight of the wrecked Red Jasper moves her.

Catra doesn't know what comes over her, she *really* doesn't, but the image sends grief washing over her like a wave. Tears stream down her face like they haven't in years and her breath heaves and hiccups. She Ra whips around at the sound. Her face shits from awe to concern in a flash and she's making her way to Catra.

"Catra? What- what's…are you…okay?" By the time she reaches her She Ra has melted away and it's Adora who wraps Catra in her arms.

Catra doesn't look up to see how Bow and Glitter react, she doesn't want to know. She burrows her head into Adora's neck. "I don't *know*!" She wails. "It-I-I don't *know*. Wh-why is it so broken? H-how? Why do *I* feel so broken?"

"I'm not sure Cat, what can I do?"

Catra looks up meekly, more than a little embarrassed by the mess she's sure she's made of herself. "Can you fix it?"

The set of Adora's jaw turns stubborn and Catra realizes what she's said a moment too late. She doesn't ask Adora to fix things; Adora's fixed plenty and the requests for her aid continue to roll in-even years after she literally *saved the planet*. It's messed up and Catra never wants to be the one to enforce her girlfriend's hero complex. She looks over at the shattered stone again. A fresh wave of horror envelopes her and she resigns herself; maybe this is an acceptable exception.

"I can fix it." Adora asserts, and She Ra is back before she's even fully released Catra.

“Adora…are you sure you know what you’re doing?” Glimmer asks tentatively. “If that really is a lost runestone it’s got to have like, a ton of magical energy…”

“Please, I got this.” Glimmer raises her arms in submission and, even given the circumstances, Catra can’t help but snicker at She Ra’s cocky swagger.

She approaches the stone with the sword drawn and the rest of them watch on with bated breath. She points the sword of protection at the shards and a glowing beam shoots from the tip. After a moment the shards also begin to glow and Glimmer gasps. Catra feels her body pitch forward ever so slightly in anticipation as they start to rattle around on the ground.

She Ra holds the beam steady but after a couple minutes Catra can see her jaw clench with exertion and beads of sweat begin to gather at her temples. She feels herself blush slightly when it reminds her of…actually doesn’t matter what it reminds her of. Especially since, after another several minutes of the shards clattering around, they drop again, their glow fading in an instant. The force of the beam returning to the sword knocks She Ra back, Bow steps forward to give her something to crash into so she doesn’t fall on her butt.

Adora groans loudly. “*What?* What was that? Stupid-I know this can work!” She launches forward again as if to give it another go but Bow catches her elbow.

“Adora! Maybe we should…”

“We should *what* Bow?” She Ra snaps.

“Babe.” Catra grabs her attention and, once she has it, shakes her head gently. As resignation takes over Adora returns to herself.

“I’m sorry,” Her voice breaks ever so slightly. “I know I can make this work if I can just- “

“I know you can too Adora.” Catra cuts her off. “I know you can, but I think maybe we need to know more first. Maybe go back to see George and Lance.” Adora pouts but nods.

“So…do we just leave it, or…?” Glimmer looks dubiously at the wrecked runestone.

No one seems eager to leave it behind, but it’s been shattered into so many pieces…. Eventually they work it out; She Ra is able to stack most of them so they don’t pile too high for her to and carry them out, and Glimmer and Catra share the load of two smallest shards. Meanwhile Bow keeps his tracker pad handy and leads them out of the Waste.

They reach Brightmoon and decide the best place for the stone is the meeting room. The Princess Alliance won’t meet again for a few days, so that gives them some time to figure this out before they need the space again.

“So..” They stand around the shattered stone and Glimmer looks at each of them in turn. “what now?”

“Well, anyone know how to fix a runestone?” Adora asks back.

“I mean, isn’t She Ra best quipped for this kind of thing?”

Adora’s face falls and Catra seethes. “Knock it off Sparkles.”

“*What?* I’m just saying- “

“Yeah, well don’t. We tried Plan A, time to see what we can do about Plan B.”

Glimmer cuts her eyes to Adora and they widen when she finally registers her upset. “Okay…back to the library? There were a lot of Magicat scrolls left. Catra, you ready for some marathon studying?”

Her eyes roll but she relents. “Fine, but don’t you dare turn down George’s cookies on my behalf this time.”

Adora nods seriously. “Yeah, not cool Glim.”

Glimmer scoffs. “You two are perfect for each other.”

Adora reaches over to grab Catra’s hand and she smiles dopily at her. “Yeah, that’s true.”

“Gross, Princess.” Catra smiles wide through her insult and Adora takes it like a compliment. They both ignore Glimmer’s response, too lost in their own bubble to care what she has to say.

Chapter End Notes

> This was the first chapter I wrote! Always neat to catch up to where I start a story, because starting in the middle is very much my vibe.
>
> Thanks for reading, and double to folks who have shared your thoughts!! I love reading them, they got me all gooey on the inside :)

The Last of Us

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Stuffed full of cookies, Catra settles in at a desk with a pile of scrolls. There are strangely *a lot* more recipes, apparently the Magicats liked to eat. Catra can appreciate that, outside the world of ration bars food is a truly magical thing. However, having grown accustom to the cuisine of Brightmoon, the rodents, cacti and plethora of all things pickled that keep showing up don't sound altogether appetizing to Catra.

Ultimately the scrolls don't turn up much. There's some interesting stuff about queens that came before Saz, a lot of that is about the queen she had succeeded. Evidently, she advanced their tech by exponential proportions; She invented a new weapon that was some sort of laser boomerang thing intended to be thrown at the enemy. The scroll said it was powerful enough to cut through anything it contacted. Included in the list of material it could cut through were platinum and bone, the thought alone makes Catra shiver. There was a crude drawing that looked rather like a paw with lines shooting out of the parts where the claws ought to be. Catra honestly kind of wants one, but she's not sure she trusts Entrapta enough to ask her if she can recreate it.

Long after the sun has gone down, and Glimmer and Bow have started to doze on the couch Catra reaches the last scroll.

"To my Successor,

I don't know how our people will find you, but I believe it will take many years after I am gone. I hope to be able to repair the damage I have done to the Red Jas- "

Catra sits up in her chair, her energy suddenly returned to her. The movement catches Adora's attention. She's been sitting

across the table from Catra, fighting off sleep while she skims through a book about the ecology of the Crimson Waste.

"Did you find something?"

"I think so, listen;" This manages to stir Bow who in turn wakes Glimmer with his shifting. They scoot down the couch closer to their friends as Catra begins to read the scroll again.

"To my Successor,

I don't know how our people will find you, but I believe it will take many years after I am gone. I hope to be able to repair the damage I have done to the Red Jasper, but I do not know if that will be possible. Our people are in danger, every last one of us. There is a prophecy, a prophecy about ***you****. Our spies tell us that our enemies intend to wipe out every Magicat to ensure that whoever you are, you never connect to the runestone, as is your birthright.*

If the prophecy is to be believed (and I trust the prophet with my life, with all of our lives); like me, you will follow no line of succession. The prophecy tells us that regardless of the future of our people you ***will*** *be the most powerful of us, you will not carry the Magicat fire-you will be an inferno.*

Young Magicat-or perhaps you are not so young now- I will do everything in my power to protect our people. But if you ***are*** *indeed the last of us, know this; your people love you, your people believe in you, and in spirit we will never allow you to walk alone.*

By the whiskers of the Sun,
Princess Saz"

There is a stunned silence in the room. After an extended moment George and Lance mumble something about leaving the oven on and leave the others to process.

"Catra…you know you may be the last of the magicats. If you are…I think-I think that makes you a- "

"Don't say it! Adora, I'm warning you…"

Uncertainty dissolves from Adora's face and a smirk takes its place. "Aw, but babe. We could be Pr- "

"Shut up Adora!"

"Hmm, why don't you make me Pri- "

With a mighty growl Catra leaps from her chair and tackles Adora to the ground. Far from shutting her up, the move just makes Adora cackle. Without looking Catra can tell that their friends are snickering too. Her tail bushes out and thrashes wildly behind her.

"Well Catra…" Glimmer begins and Catra looks up from Adora's stupid face to glare at her. "Good thing you didn't buy property in Erelandia."

"Excuse me?" She growls, tightening her grip on Adora's shoulders until her claws just begin to unsheathe.

"Well," She snickers. "It would be pretty awkward to have bought property in the town that hates princesses, you know, considering you probably are one."

"Arghh!" Catra launches herself off Adora, who lets out a small 'oomph!' at the pressure, and tackles Glimmer this time, knocking her off the couch. "I don't care if you are queen, Sparkles. I'll kill you!"

"Please," Glimmer scoffs from underneath Catra, looking totally unfazed at being tackled to the ground. "you already tried that, remember? I seem to recall you not being able to finish the job."

Adora, who's stood up again and brushed herself off, and Bow burst into laughter. George and Lance peek their heads around

the corner to see what they're missing. Satisfied their children and their books are safe, they duck back around again.

"Can you insensitive idiots read the room please? Seriously, I hate all of you." Catra grunts before stalking out of the library. Adora tries to call after her but Catra is too enraged to so much as consider pausing.

She doesn't really have a plan of where she's going, has nowhere to go. Her world is just…a little rocked right now, and the teasing is too much. She kicks around some pebbles for a little while, then when that gets old, she springs into a tree. She finds a low branch to lounge on while she considers the weight of her existence.

Suddenly there's a pressure on her stomach and she shrieks. She looks up in the alien face of her actual, very best friend. She's lucky Melog can't tell Scorpia that, she's pretty sure it would rock her world just a little too much. Scorpia claims the title practically daily, and Catra lets her because she is genuinely a very close second.

"What are you doing here? You know you're not allowed in the library anymore." The meow indignantly back. "I literally told you not to knock that vase over. It's bad enough when you-jeez, fine-when one of us does that in Brightmoon, you can't break historical artifacts in a historian's library dude. Bad manners." She doesn't have to understand them to know how they feel about her hypocrisy; it's written all over their face.

They nudge her a few times, encouraging her to tell them what's wrong. They clearly aren't buying it when she repeatedly tells them, "It's nothing, I'm not gonna listen to some stupid, ancient scroll. I know who I am."

It comes clear as a bell; So, who are you?

"I-I'm-whatever-don't put me on the spot! Whatever it is, I am not a Princess." She sneers the word.

Who said you were?

"No one! Nothing, just...there's this stupid scroll in there. It's dumb."

Oh, would you like me to steal it? I could dispose of it in the creek.

Catra chuckles wetly and draws them into a hug, nuzzling her face into them. "Nah, but thanks buddy. I appreciate the offer."

She and Melog hand in the tree for a while and, like she knew they would, someone comes out to find her a little bit later. The only part that surprises her is that it's Bow, and not Adora, who emerges from the library.

Bow looks around for a few minutes, not thinking to look up for a stupidly long time. Everyone knows that's the direction Catra goes when she's upset. Not that she's predictable, clearly. Finally, he spots the pair in the tree. "Oh, hey Melog! Uh…" He scratches his neck awkwardly. "You know I can't invite you inside, right? My dad's are still pretty-"

Melog cuts him off with a harrumph and leaps off Catra, disappearing into the woods. "Wow, okay. Bye, I guess." She calls after their retreating form, crossing her arms and turning back to Bow when she can no longer make them out through the trees.

Bow watches them too can calls out, "Sorry! I'll see you back at Brightmoon!"

"What are you doing out here?" Catra sasses, pulling Bow's focus to her.

Far from offended, Bow just shrugs. He drops to the ground in front of the tree where Catra continues to lounge and leans back against the trunk with is legs folded in front of him. "Figured you could use some company. Thought maybe some of the non-princess variety might be welcome right about now. They say sorry by the way."

Catra softens slightly at this but still she scoffs. "I am not- "

"Catra, I don't know if you can say that for sure right now."

"Well I don't want to be. Doesn't that matter?"

Bow cranes his head to look up at her. "Of course, it does. That doesn't mean it changes anything though. And if you are…well, you get to decide what that means."

Catra pauses to think about this. What does it mean if she is in fact a-a…? She groans internally. For Mara's sake, she can't even think it.

"Can I ask you something?" Bow correctly takes her silence as assent. "Would it really be so bad if you were?"

"What? "

"I mean, you're already a part of the Princess Alliance now. The princesses aren't your enemies anymore, they haven't been for a long time. Plus, if you were that would probably mean you'd get powers, right?"

Interest piqued Catra sits up, she hadn't thought of that. "You think?"

Bow shrugs. "I mean if we can repair the stone; I don't see why not."

"Okay…I could get into that part." She hesitates, grateful Bow is looking into the woods and not at her face. She feels…afraid. She's better at admitting that to herself now, but she still hates herself for it. "What-what does it mean though Bow? I-I mean if I'm a, ugh, a princess, does that mean I have like, a queendom out there to rule or something? We don't even know if there's anyone else left!"

Bow takes a minute to answer. "I don't know Catra." He cranes his neck to look up at her again, she holds the eye contact despite ever instinct telling her to look away. "But don't you think you owe it to yourself to at least find out?"

“Maybe….” She hesitates but the words stuck in her throat feel like they’re trying to claw their way out. There’s no way she can keep this to herself. “There’s something else.”

Bow raises his eyebrows. “What else?”

Catra sighs, “There was a note, in the margin. The handwriting, it was different, but it said…” Bow waits patiently as Catra gathers herself. “It says, ‘Without connection, there is no completion.’”

Bows eyes widen comically. “Catra, do you think that means…”

She huffs, impatient, and stressed, and overwhelmed by grief over the probable outcome of her lineage. “Yeah Bow, I think it does.”

Chapter End Notes

Did I already update today? Was that yesterday? Who can say? But here I am again! And it's almost midnight so the point is technically moot anyway.

Thanks to folks reading this story and sharing your thoughts. This is a new direction for me and the comments I've received have been so validating and appreciated!!

Like a Whip

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Not here."

"Wha- Catra…"

"Not here." She reiterates firmly.

"Okay, so what? You want us to drag it back to the middle of nowhere?" Melog winds between Catra's legs and the waves of their mane sharpen slightly.

"Listen Sparkles, you want me to do this? Fine, but you're gonna have to trust my instincts. We do it in the Waste."

Glimmer opens her mouth to argue again but Adora cuts her off. "Catra's right." Melog settles and sinks down onto their belly, still between Catra's legs. "We're doing this her way. Maybe we should load it up in Darla this time? It'll make the journey quicker at least."

Catra shoots her girlfriend a grateful smile and nods. "Still not coming bud?" She looks down at Melog. They don't even deign to respond; Catra knows they've been wary of the ship ever since landing on Brightmoon the first time. They came on the road trip to restore magic but Catra suspects that's because they knew just how many times them being there was going to save everyone's butts. And anyway, they're also not a huge fan of sand that clings to them in the Crimson Waste. She didn't really need to bother asking, but she knows they like to feel wanted-even when there's not a chance they're interested. "Yeah, okay. Figures."

With that decided the plan is set. A few guards help them load up the ship after lunch and they take off as soon as they're ready.

“Was this one over here…or was it this other one?” She Ra balances a shard in each hand and Bow considers his options, scratching his chin. Catra hides a snicker at the attention it draws to the tiny beard he’s been growing.

“I’m not sure…I thought the one on the right was more in the southeast section.”

“Uh…my right or your right?”

“Adora, I *really* don’t think this is necessary.” Catra says, not for the first time.

She gets a frown in response. “But you said to put it back where it was.” Adora says, also not for the first time.

Catra groans and throws up her hands. “Just let them have their fun.” Glimmer teases from where she’s hiding in the shade.

“Whatever.” Catra huffs, moving to lay by her, a little to the right so she can stretch out in the sun.

Bow and Adora work a while longer, debating the location of each shard. At long last they call over to their girlfriends, finally satisfied with their work. “Alright Catra,” Bow prompts. “you ready to do this?”

Catra frowns but gets up to stand by the broken runestone nevertheless. Her arms hang awkwardly by her sides until she grabs an arm with the opposite hand, and she curls her tail around one leg. “Okay, so…what do I do here? Just…I don’t know, am I just supposed to look at it really hard?”

“Uh…you just kind of…connect?” She Ra looks uncertainly over to Glimmer.

“It’s hard to put into words, I don’t know. It’s like connecting with a person, you know? You have a relationship of sorts with your

runestone once you've connected."

"A relationship?" Catra verifies doubtfully.

"Just like…try to tune in with the energy of the Red Jasper. Then you can engage in an exchange of energy; connecting."

Catra scoffs and raises an eyebrow. Her tail releases her leg and flicks from side to side. "Sounds like you want me to take it on a date. It's hokey, but sure I'll court this stupid rock or whatever. Hope you don't get too jealous over there, Princess."

"Okay, well you're gonna have to think up a new nickname after this, you know that, right?" Adora smirks at the scowl Catra shoots her way.

"Shut up. And don't tell me what to do." She turns away, toward the Red Jasper and huffs, moving a little closer. She just…stands there…and waits. She can feel everyone's eyes on her, and it makes the skin on her neck crawl. She whips around and, of course, they all turn away awkwardly and do a poor job of pretending they weren't just staring at her. "Can you dummies like…do something else?"

"Catra, we're in the middle of nowhere. What do you want us to do?" Glimmer points out, her hand on her hip.

Catra balls up her fists and breathes, counting to ten like Perfuma had taught her. That woman has an incredible amount of relaxation techniques on hand. It had frankly baffled Catra until she realized Perfuma is a bigger ball of anxiety than even Adora had ever been. Or, she was a least. The whole not being at war thing certainly seemed to help. And Catra's noticed her get better and better at taking her own advice over the last couple years. A feat not achieved without a little uh…playful encouragement from Catra.

Even with the self-soothing Catra grits her teeth when she responds. "I don't really care *what* you do Sparkles, but this is

never gonna work with the three of you watching me like a pack of vultures."

"Fine." Glimmer sniffs.

"Hey, let's, Bow didn't you say Entrapta showed you some updates she made to the ship? Will you show us?"

"Great idea Adora!" Bow answers, spinning on his heal. His cheery tone is one hundred percent forced but all Catra cares about is the fact that they're *leaving*.

Their voices fade as they shuffle back onto the ship and Catra heaves a sigh of relief. Tired of standing awkwardly at the edge of the circle of wrecked stone she stalks to the center and drops down, sitting cross legged in the sand. She sits and tries to "feel the energy" or whatever. All she feels is foolish. This whole thing is stupid, as if *she* of all people is gonna be some long lost Magicat princess. As if *she* is supposed to be the one to repair this long lost runestone. So dumb…

As she sits there, she starts to feel deeply grounded into the earth. It's nice; she imagines this is the feeling Perfuma is trying to get her to capture during all of those meditation sessions. It occurs to her that she's never before felt so completely *safe*. She also starts to feel…stronger, empowered. I mean, who's to say she *couldn't* be a Princess? Bow is right, they aren't her enemies anymore; she'd go so far as to say they're her best friends. And look what being a Princess has done for Scorpia! That woman has never been so self-assured in her life.

So yeah, if this is where they're at…Catra can do this, Catra can be a princess. Having magic powers would also be pretty damn cool. She hardly needs them, Catra is strong- her claws can cut through *metal* for Mara's sake! Catra is a warrior, Catra is powerful, Catra is a Princess. She feels a fire ignite in her belly; it burns in a way that makes her spine stretch until she sits tall, the crown of her head stretching toward the sun. She feels ready to take on *anything*.

Then the ground begins to violently shake.

She can't help the loud, squeaky shriek that flies from her mouth as her eyes pop open to survey her surroundings. She hadn't even realized she closed them in the first place. Her friends come running out of the ship.

"Catra! What is it? Catra, ba- oh my holy stars…" Adora gasps. She screeches to a halt a couple meters from the edge of the circle Catra is sitting in the center of. Her sudden stop sends Bow and Glimmer crashing into her back.

As it turns out it isn't the *ground* that's shaking. The shards of the runestone have begun to rattle on the ground, the force of it pushing and pulling at the ground and the air around them. Catra at least seems to be protected by some kind of forcefield. This proves extremely lucky when, in the next moment, they begin to rise and swirl in the air around and above her. The sand around her kicks up in the whirlwhind.

As far as Catra can tell Bow and Adora had been *very* misguided in their attempt to arrange the stone. The shards are swapping places left and right. Catra turns her head up to watch as they finally move together and form a perfect sphere in the air above her.

Catra shouldn't even be surprised when weird things get weirder anymore, she really shouldn't. It's happened enough times since Adora defected that there's really no excuse. Yet she still lets out a surprised squeak when the runestone begins to glow with an orange aura which then forms a column that envelops her. In short, Catra is freaking glowing orange.

"Adora…"

"You're okay Catra!" Adora whips her head around to look at Glimmer. "She's okay, right?"

"How am *I* supposed to know?"

“Can you make it *stop*? Point your stupid sword at me or something.”

“What’s that gonna do?” Adora turns back to her, looking thoroughly distressed.

“Guys, I’m sure it’s fine and will work itself out.” Bow uses his best peacekeeper voice. “Remember when this happened at the battle of Brightmoon? And that was a *good* thing.”

“Ugh, I forgot about that. Why are all you Princesses so *weird*? I can’t believe this is my life now….”

“Wait, Catra! Do you realize what this means?”

“Focus Adora! Can we please get me to stop glowing *and then* worry about the implications of this?”

“Right, yeah, okay so…” She turns to Bow this time. “what do we do?”

“Well…when this happened before- “ Bow cuts off, his eyes wide.

“What? What about when this happened before?”

“Uh…”

“Yeah, you and Sparkles are doing it now too.” Catra informs her, her voice now devoid of emotion.

“Huh? Oh!” Glimmer and Adora inspect each other.

“You think it’s happening to the others too?” Glimmer asks.

Adora shrugs back. “Probably.”

“My life is an actual nightmare.”

“When this happened before didn’t it like, reinforce everyone’s powers? Do you guys feel more powerful?”

Adora scrunches her moth to one side. "Uh…. For the Honor of Grayskull!" She Ra appears without the lights show this time and waves her sword around a little. "Actually, yeah, a little bit. Glimmer?"

"Let's see…" Out of nowhere she shoots some sparkles into the sand. It's way too close to Catra for her comfort and she squeaks, *again*. She looks where they hit and sees that the sand has been smoothed into glass. "Okay…so *definitely* a little extra juice. Catra, how do you feel?"

"Uh…I mean, yeah before all of…" She gestures vaguely to herself, the sphere above her and the column of light that connects them. "*this*, I did feel pretty powerful. And like, there's this weird burning in my stomach."

"What, like heartburn?"

"Yeah Glitter, like heartburn." Catra's voice is all sarcasm and no patience. "No, like…I don't know. It just feels…"

"Powerful?" Adora supplies.

Catra stands and shakes herself off a little. The red Jasper hovers, buzzing a little ways above her head. "Blech, fine, yes."

"Babe do you, can you like, *do* anything?" Catra just raises an unimpressed brow at her. "You know what I mean."

"I don't know, how would I even do something like that?"

"Uh, I dunno. Maybe there's like, a gesture or something. Getting any sort of gut instinct?"

Catra rolls her eyes but goes ahead and does the first thing that comes to her. She swipes a hand through the air as if to scratch at something. A hot trail of fire swings out from her hand like a whip, lashing close enough to her friends that they jump back.

Catra jumps in surprise and shrieks, falling backward and outside the circle of the column. When she does the light around her, the Red Jasper, and the other two princesses present begins to fade. "Sorry! Shoot, are you guys okay?"

She scurries to her feet and rushes over to inspect the others. They all look unharmed and Bow rushes to assure her, "Catra, we're all fine, but that! That was *amazing*!"

"Seriously!" Glimmer jumps on board. "You were all like, *swish!* And the fire was all, *whip!* " She makes a few more weird noises and does a crude reenactment of the event.

"Yeah! And those flames were *huge*, did you guys see that?" Bow adds on.

"Totally! Even from a couple feet away they were hot enough I thought it was gonna burn our eyebrows off or something. So cool!"

While Bow and Glimmer gush Adora remains silent. Catra turns to gauge her reaction; she's back to her usual self, staring wide eyed and open mouthed at Catra. Her cheeks are flushed, and she has yet to blink. Catra scratches behind one ear uncertainly and it flicks awkwardly when she pulls her hand away.

"Uh…Adora? You okay over there?"

That snaps her out of her reverie with a start. "Huh? Yeah, oh yeah, totally. That was, um, neat?" She winces like she can hear just how ridiculous it sounds. In any other circumstance Catra would tease her, but she's a little preoccupied right now.

"Yeah?"

Adora nods emphatically. "Yeah, I mean Catra that was…you're amazing. Can you um, would you do it again?"

"Again? I mean, su- "

"Uh, are we sure that's a good idea? How good of control do you really have over this?"

Catra turns to give Glimmer a dubious look. "Really Glitter? And where is gonna be safer to experiment with this that the middle of an endless sea of sand?"

"Alright, point taken. Just maybe stand *a little* further away this time."

Figuring that's really for the best Catra doesn't argue. She stalks a few feet further away than she was before and takes a deep breath. "Okay, so…like a whip." She whispers to herself.

One more deep breath and on the exhale, she flicks her wrist. Another trail of flames bursts forth, burning even higher than last time. This time, instead of reaching the end of its trajectory and burning out, it swings until it forms a line in front of her and settles so there is a wall of flame separates her from the others. She eyes it wearily, deducing quickly that it isn't going anywhere anytime soon.

She notices with interest that despite only being a foot away the heat isn't blistering.

"Catra? How's it going over there?" Adora calls out.

In fact, it leaves a pleasant tickling sensation on her skin.

"I'm fine! Gimme a second." Curiously she sticks a hand out. Even as she draws closer and closer to the flames the pleasant feeling remains. She fully submerges her hand and pulls it back quickly to inspect it. It looks exactly the same as before. Her next idea is reckless and stupid and down right dangerous. She decides to go for it.

Crouching slightly Catra leaps through the wall of flames. She lands on her feet on the other side, unharmed and feeling better than ever. When she looks up at the others there staring at her,

awestruck. She preens as Bow breathes out the words, “The *Inferno*.”

Then, predictably, Adora cuts through all the tension and awe in the air with a loud snort. “Aw, babe! Did you just jump through fire to get to me? I love it when you do that.”

Chapter End Notes

> Catra should have gotten to keep her whip after they left the Crimson Waste and I will die on that hill. She was gay as hell with that whip.
>
> Thanks to everyone reading along and to those of you who are sweet enough to share your thoughts!! I'm really enjoying writing this one so much!

Do You Understand?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Uh…hey Catra?" Bow interrupts her and Adora's bantering. "Your instincts telling you anything about how to *put out* the fire?"

"Huh?" She looks to where he's pointing, at the wall of flames still burning behind her. "Oh, uh…" She tries a sort of wiping motion and jumps when the flames do the same in response. "So maybe not that…" This time she tries more of a…horizontal slicing motion with both hands, moving them apart from each other. It seems to work, and the flames die down, leaving the sand steaming in their wake.

"Oh, thank Mara." Glimmer sighs, visibly relaxing.

"Pfft, those flames weren't anywhere near you near you Sparkles!"

"Catra! Don't be cavalier about this! Flames *spread*. You've got a lot of power now and that's really cool and all, but you have to be careful."

"Funny, I thought you were the Queen of Brightmoon, not the Queen of minding *my* damn business." Catra scoffs, buffing her nails on her shoulder.

"Uh...guys?" Adora ventures.

Glimmer ignores her, spluttering away for a minute. "Queen of… *excuse me*, but I've had powers for much longer that you have! Don't be stupid and not take my advice because you're too proud-
"

"*Too proud?* Give it a rest Glimmer, you're the one underestimating me! Obviously I know that *"fire spreads"* . Just

because I seem to have better spatial awareness than you doesn't mean- "

"Guys!" Bow hollers at them, he and Adora have scooted closer together and are almost starting to shrink into each other. When they both turn to him, fuming, he puts his hands up meekly. "Sorry! Sorry, it's just um…" He points across them and they turn to look.

The Red Jasper's low buzzing has escalated to a frenzied vibration. "Ugh, what is this? Melog is bad enough, I don't need a giant rock responding to my emotions too!" She knows she's whining but this is getting beyond ridiculous.

She doesn't have time to lament this much further however, because the Red Jasper has begun to rapidly plummet toward the ground. She whips around to look at her friends. "I'm dreaming right? I'm gonna wake up and *we*- " She gestures between Adora and herself. She doesn't even flinch when there's a loud crash from behind her that makes everyone else's jaw drop, too consumed in her rampage. "are gonna be back at the Horde! Just when I was starting to like it here too. Well that's just great, truly fabulous. Thanks for the memories, I suppose."

No one says anything. Adora just marches forward, her expression still frozen into one of shock, and grabs Catra by the shoulders to turn her around…. She imagines her face looks pretty much like everyone else's now. The Red Jasper has not only plummeted to the ground, but through it. Now it hovers below the ground over a marble dais which stands roughly four or five stories high. Catra inches closer to see that the dais appears to be standing in a round chamber carved into the red rock of the Crimson Waste, with tunnels branching off of it on every level. Saz's tunnels.

Catra gulps and jumps when Adora speaks right next to her. "How is anyone even supposed to get *down* there?"

"I dunno Princess."

“Hey,” Adora look of wonder shifts into something distinctly more teasing. “watch who you’re calling Princess, Princess.”

“Ugh, let’s not make this a *thing*, shall we?”

“Oh, Catra, baby no. We are *definitely* gonna make this a thing.”

Glimmer’s voice on her other side makes her jump again. “Yeah, after all, we gotta make up for lost time. Don’t you think, Princess?”

“I only love Bow. You two can fall into this chamber for all I care.”

“*Aww!* ” Bow coos from Glimmer’s other side. “Princess Catra, you *love* me?”

“Wow, pretty embarrassing for you babe.” Adora teases.

“Nope! Never mind, you can all fall together. Just let me know if you need a push.”

Adora looks over the edge at that. “You think there’s anyone left down there?”

Everyone looks at Catra like the Red Jasper also made her omniscient in addition to giving her ability to control fire. “How am I supposed to know?”

“Right, of course.” Adora covers. “But…um, any ideas on how to get down there?”

“No.” Catra defends, but she looks at the chamber below anyway, studying it. Something, just a flash really, catches her eye. It could be nothing but…. She walks around the circle, 90 degrees from where she started, and crouches down. What she’s seeing…it reminds her of the way she can still sort of see Melog when they create the illusion of invisibility. Adora insists there’s nothing to see, but she’s definitely wrong.

Something tickles the hairs on the back of Catra's neck and it feels oddly like intuition whispering in her ear. She doesn't question it and she thrusts her hand in front of her, sending out a roaring column of flame. They crackle down along the chamber walls in a spiral and in their wake is a set of polished black stairs. She blinks in moderate surprise and looks up to see that her companions' surprise could in no way be described as 'moderate'. "Uh…this way I guess?"

She lets Glimmer, Bow then Adora start down the steps before her and follows suit. She notices Adora's cheeks have pinkened and as they begin to descend, she distinctly hears her say something to the effect of, "…*way* too gay for this…" in a hysterical whisper. Frankly, Catra has never felt so cocky in her entire thrice damned life.

The reach the top floor and pause at the tunnel. It's illuminated by torchlight and Adora wonders aloud, "Wait, torches…does that mean…?"

"It's not real fire." Three sets of eyes swivel to Catra. "*What?* I can just tell." Adora's whine is ever so subtle and Catra arches an eyebrow at her.

"Hey, uh, guys? Why don't you see if any of the passageways on the next level look promising and we'll check out the rest of these? Uh Glimmer, maybe check that all of the fire is illusionary."

Glimmer smirks knowingly at her best friend. "Whatever you say Adora. Come on Bow." She drags him off and as they descend the next section of stairs Adora starts to shift around.

"Hey Adora."

"Hey, so I like, really want to kiss you right now. Is that okay?"

"Aww, Adora, is my fire getting you hot?"

Her expression sets into something altogether defiant. "So what if it is?"

Catra just laughs at her and pulls her down the passage next to them. A little way in she backs herself into the wall and pulls Adora to her for a searing kiss. She pushes her back when they break apart to catch their breath but doesn't let go of her shoulders. "I *really* want to finish this later, but right now…"

"Yeah." Adora nods, her smile dopey. "Yeah no, I get it. We should keep looking around. I just…"

Catra smirks, "Yeah, I get it."

They emerge from the passageway and look down a few more tunnels. They're about to finish up this level when a harsh whisper floats up from the third. "You guys!" Glimmer whisper-shouts. "Get down here."

The share a look and then scurry down to meet their friends. They don't need to ask why they've been summoned; in addition to the flickering heat of real flames, music filters from a distance. Catra is also able to pick up the distinct scent of incense. Her heart beats wildly in her chest over the implications of this.

"You ready?" Adora asks softly.

She gives her a gentle smile in return. "As I'll ever be, I guess." She grips her arm above her elbow and coils her tail around Adora's leg but leads the charge into the tunnel. It's long but not terribly so and Catra isn't sure what she was expecting, but it isn't what she finds.

They emerge into an underground greenhouse of sorts, it's like an indoor jungle. The air feels fresh and clear, and a marble waterfall trickles down the center of a long wall. In the center of the room is an ornate rug in deep shades of green that reflect the plants around it. There is a dark, sturdy wooden table in the middle of it, low to the ground. It holds the burning incense Catra smelled from the chamber and a dozen or so candles in gold, red and orange.

Around the table, sat on cushions on the ground, are three Magicats. Catra notices that they take up two sides of the table and along the other two are four cushions. The two magicats who share a side are colored not dissimilarly to Catra, though there is a distinct red tone to their fur that Catra lacks. And the third Magicat is a dark black, the night sky devoid of moons and stars.

"Ah, Princess Catra, you've made it." Catra feels every eye in the room land of her.

"Who the hell are you?" She's flustered by her own lack of decorum, but more so by the presence of the first people she ever remembers seeing who look like her.

The black Magicat smiles serenely. "I imagine that is not the only question you have young princess. Please, sit. Let us get your questions squared away and then you and I shall go for a walk."

Catra eyes her warily but Adora nudges her forward. She stumbles on her first step and turns to glare at her but carries herself to the cushion opposite this mysterious person. Everyone else follows and sits as well.

"Now, to answer your question; My name is Percival. This is Orwall and Tao, the three of us maintain the magic that sustains these tunnels. They are Magi and I am the Prophet, descendant of Prophet Cloudfoot who delivered the prophecy that led us here today."

"I…I don't even know where to start." Catra notices with gratitude that her friends are holding back, uncharacteristically reserved so that she can take the reins. "Magi, is that not-we were told that's the Magicat language."

"Ah, a common misconception in the outside world. Translated into Etherian they are spelled the same, but the accenting is different in your native tongue. Mag-eye are those who wield magic, able to draw power from the air they breathe. Mag-gee is our language."

“Oh. So…there are…are there others? Like us.”

Percival’s smile grows a little more somber. “Very few, but yes. The Magicats have never been large in numbers and we lost many to the attacks after the Great Prophecy was made. Princess Saz saved many lives when she used the Red Jasper to create these tunnels.”

“Used the Red Jasper?” Adora interrupts, seemingly unable to help herself.

Percival seems to hold back a smile at her candor. “Yes. Princess Catra, I assume you have already wielded the Magicat Flames, yes?

“Uh, yeah. A-above ground, a little.”

“Yes, once you have accessed the fire within you it remains a source of life force and heat; easy to access. There are subtler things, power that will only come with time and patience, that you will learn.”

Catra’s eyes pop wide. “Hold on, what are you saying? What else can I do?”

“Hm…there are reasons not every Magicat is born a prophet young princess. I will keep that to myself for now.”

“Oh.” Catra deflates. “So, uh...what does this mean? A-are people expecting me to…? Where *are* all the people?”

“The Queendom of Halfmoon is not what it once was. In many ways you could say that it really it is no more. It was Saz’s recommendation to the council that Halfmoon evolve and become a democracy. But the Magicats still have need of you Princess Catra, all of Etheria does. Even repaired, the Red Jasper requires connection; an exchange of energy with the living Magicat most capable of carrying its power within themselves. In this age, it is you Princess Catra. You will be as much a warrior for you people as you are royalty. In requiring your connection to sustain, the

Red Jasper chooses you to use its power to protect those you love and the home you and the runestone share.

"It is worth noting; you will not always walk alone in this young princess. Your connection with the Red Jasper is special. It may be because you repaired the runestone and that is a bond that can never be broken. Just as likely is that this connection is special purely because of the incredible power you bring to your connection with the runestone. Whatever the reason; your cup runneth over."

"Okay…what does that mean?"

Percival smirks. "There will come a time when you share that excess with another, one whose power will be capable of matching your own someday."

Catra eyes the prophet suspiciously. "You know who, don't you?" Percival raises an eyebrow at her. "And you're not going to tell me, are you?"

"Why, Princess Catra, where on Etheria would be the fun in that?" She flits her gaze to Adora briefly and the back of Catra's neck tickles with intuition once again.

"Whatever, so where is everyone?"

"Ah, well as I said the Magicats' leadership transformed into a democracy. We remained underground for many years. After generations passed and the Great Prophecy faded in the minds of our enemies, we returned above ground for a time. However, shortly after we did so the Horde invaded, and we returned underground once again. Many of our people chose to venture out, to fight for justice. Many were lost this way; without the power of the Red Jasper our warriors did not have the might they did in our history.

"Those of us that remain live peacefully in Halfmoon on the lower levels or choose a more nomadic lifestyle. Once a year all Magicats gather in Halfmoon, those who do not live here

pilgrimage in time for the Summer Solstice. We emerge to the surface to pay tribute to our lives, the lives of those we love, the lives of those we've lost, and the life we know will come. And we honor the sun whose fire fuels our own."

There is a long silence around the table while the newcomers digest the load of information. "Catra?" Adora asks in a small, timid voice. She places a hand on Catra's knee when she doesn't respond. Catra takes it in her own and squeezes tightly once.

"Princess Catra, let us take a walk. Orwall and Tao will remain to answer any further questions your loved ones may have." The other Magicats smile warmly at their guests.

"Oh, okay." Catra stands with a nervous look in Adora's direction. She smiles encouragingly back, and it steels Catra's nerves just enough to follow Percival back out the way they had come in.

They lead Catra up a floor and down another tunnel, at the end of this one is the begging if a loop. The path seems to curve around the edge of the tunnel system and is lined with fruit trees. "This place is…how does it work?"

The Prophet smiles, and the look is more than a little mischievous. "Magic of course, Princess Catra."

"I-you don't have to call me that."

"Oh, I know. I hope you'll forgive the formality; it is just my way."

"Uh, sure. Whatever you want, I guess." They continue to stroll for a while and Catra grows restless. Luckily Percival breaks the silence for her.

"So, Princess, no doubt there are questions you have: questions you did not wish to ask in front of those you love. Am I mistaken?"

"Well…no. A couple, I guess. I…I can read Magi."

“Yes, I suppose you would be able to, wouldn’t you?”

“How is that possible? I’d never even heard of it, let alone seen it, until we started looking for the Red Jasper.”

Percival considers Catra from the corner of their eye for several paces. “Hmm, is that certain?”

“What is that supposed to mean?” Catra feels her tail bush slightly and reaches to smooth the fur down.

“What is your first memory Catra?”

“What? I-Adora I guess, I remember meeting Adora. There’s nothing before the Fright Zone. Do you…do you know how I ended up there?”

“I do.”

“Well are you gonna tell me?” Catra asks, a bit of her impatience leaking into her voice.

“Let’s sit, shall we?” Catra turns to where she indicates and is surprised to see a bench between the trees, carved into the red rock. She follows the elder Magicat and sits beside her. “As I mentioned before; when the Horde invaded, and our people moved underground, the warriors among us refused to sit idly by. To fight for justice has been the Magicat way, for as long as we have existed…. You look troubled, will you tell me why?”

“Huh, no I’m fine. You can keep going.”

“You will find, little Princess, that a prophet is much harder to fool than that.”

Catra bristles then instantly deflates. “I’m fine, really.”

“I believe I understand why you are upset. Allow me to finish and we shall see if I am right, hm?”

“Sure, that’s fine.”

“So, as I said; many brave Magicats fought, and among them were your parents.” Catra involuntarily gasps at the answer to the unasked part of her question. Obviously she knew she must have had parents but…she never let herself believe she had parents who *wanted* her, or who stood for anything. Shadow Weaver saw to that. “To return to your first question; Princess Catra, you know Magi because you learned it. You attended lessons here with your peers. I’m told you were quite the precocious little learner.”

“Why don’t I remember that? And how can I remember how to read it if I don’t remember learning it?”

Percival shrugs. “Trauma I presume.”

“Oh.” What an anticlimactic answer, Catra could’ve guessed *that*.

“After your parents left for the battle from which they did not return, you grew restless. You ran away Princess, you went to the surface to look for them. At the time the surface was no place for one so small and you were soon captured. My parent, the Prophet who came before me, suspected you were the Princess of whom the Great Prophecy foretold. Your kidnapping was an unfortunate confirmation to these suspicions. The Prophet and their advisors went to look for you and witnessed your capture. They pleaded for your life, but there was a price.”

“A price?”

“Yes; information. The Dark Sorceress led the Horde troops into battle and when you were caught, she commanded that you and the other prisoners be killed. So, the Prophet told her of the great power you possessed, how you alone would be able to restore the Red Jasper. Hungry for power, she spared you. We believe she thought the prophet to be lying but would not risk access to a second runestone. It was a very dark day for every Magicat, Princess Catra; past, present and future. It was an especially dark

day for you. It is no wonder your own mind would seek to protect you."

"Shadow Weaver." Catra murmurs bitterly.

"Hm, yes, I believe that is the name many knew The Dark Sorceress by."

Catra snorts. "Yeah, one of many." Catra runs through a short list of vulgar insults she had brainstormed over her years under Shadow Weaver's care in her mind.

"The Sorceress, she was cruel to you."

Catra scoffs. "You could say that."

"Hm, and she warped your sense of reality, of right versus wrong." Catra feels her face flush deeply. "There is no need to be ashamed Princess Catra." Percival taps their temple. "I am fully aware of your history, and I am not here to judge you. It is my role to guide and to love you."

Catra sucks in a breath at their words. "Oh."

"You know what it is like to fight for the wrong side, to seek the destruction of justice. And you know what it is like to empathize with those that seek to commit acts of evil. It is not in alignment with the Magicat way, and this is why you are upset, yes?"

A deep sense of shame fills Catra and she feels an old, familiar desire to run away. "Yeah-yes."

"Tell me Catra, all those terrible things; are they in alignment with who you know yourself to be now, now that you have had the opportunity to know yourself for who you truly are?"

"No, they're not." She responds fiercely.

"And your newfound power, will you seek destruction with its force?"

Catra flushes with a hot mix of emotions; shame, betrayal, and indignation among them. “Of course not.”

“Then I suggest you let go of your shame Princess Catra. It will not serve you, in fact it will only work to hinder your power.”

Catra scoffs. “Yeah, well it’s not that simple. I’ve done a lot to be ashamed of.”

She looks down but her head snaps up at the Prophet’s next words. “You are thinking of the Queen, are you not?”

Her face scrunches. “What does Glimmer have to do with this?” Percival just regards her patiently. “You’re talking about Angella, aren’t you?”

“I am.”

“Yeah, well. Like I said, I’ve done a lot to be ashamed of.” Prophet Percival is quiet for some time, leaving Catra to stew in her emotions. She gets so lost in them that it startles her when her companion speaks once more.

“It is my experience, young princess, that clinging to regret does little more than sever us from the possibilities of the future.”

“Okay, I know you’re like, a prophet and living underground and stuff, but these riddles are really going over my head. What does that *mean*?”

It means, Princess Catra, that the only wrong in our world that cannot be righted is an untimely *death*. Do you understand?”

Catra fights the urge to roll her eyes with everything she has in her. “Yeah, pretty sure I got it.” The Prophet Percival knows that in time this will ring true. For now they believe they have said enough on the matter.

Chapter End Notes

Hiiii again!
So, just for some clarity there's a couple bits in this chapter (not exactly subtle but I'll not give it away *totally*) that sets up for a sequel I'm thinking about maybe, possibly writing. Just depends on the vibe. But if you've caught on just know that, *no*, I'm not about to try and fit a whole other arc into the last two chapters!
Anyway, thanks loads for reading/commenting/leaving kudos!! It's all very much appreciated.
Also, if you haven't spotted it I uploaded a second part to Lucky to Have You earlier today (which is much more my typical, fluffy vibe). I'm super pleased with that story and the other lil fluffy one shot I posted recently, so this is your official invitation to check that out if you're into it!

Thanks again folks!

That Makes Her A Princess

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When they offer to stay and help with repairs to the roof the Red Jasper as smashed thorough, the Prophet Percival assures them that she and the Magi can handle it. It's honestly a huge relief. Even with She Ra Catra's not sure how they'd even begin to start fixing that whole mess.

She does sort of want to stay and meet the other Magicats who live in Halfmoon. Of course, there's also a large part of her that just wants to go *home* and hide under the blankets while she processes. The Solstice is not far off so Percival suggest that may be the right time to meet everyone. She takes the out easily and she and her friends return home.

She can tell they're all wondering what Percival said to her while they were alone. Blessedly they all seem to have decided not to push, for now at least. Or maybe the Magi had provided similar answers. She certainly isn't about to ask. Either way, Adora just tucks her under her arm and holds her close as they make their way home.

"Remember, *no* theatrics, Catra!" Glimmer's voice is shrill, her patience worn thin from the constant arguments she and Catra had volleyed back and forth on the ship.

Melog shrinks and winds his way around Catra's legs, his mane going just the red side of purple. Catra crosses her arms and scoffs. "Who knew you'd turn out to be such a *boring* queen?"

"Catra…" Adora's scolding is directly undermined by her poorly hidden smirk. It really just serves to egg Catra on.

“Catra, so help me if you set my war room on fire…”

Far from being intimidated Catra scoffs. “It’s not like we’re at war anymore. What do you even need a war room for anyway?”

Glimmer just groans in place of a response and pushes her way through the doors, ready to start the Princess Alliance meeting. Or to get it over with if we’re being perfectly accurate.

Conversation in the room comes to a halt as the group enters. They take their usual seats, Melog pausing to nudge briefly at Scorpia’s hand for a quick pet. Her poorly contained cooing pierces the silence of the room.

After a beat Mermista drawls, “So…what did we find?”

“We?” Catra snorts.

“Whatever.” She scoffs.

“Well…” Catra can feel her lips curl into a smirk and Glimmer glowers at her. “Aw, come on, Sparkles. It’ll be way better to show than to tell.”

“I *so* do not have that much confidence in you, horde scum.”

“Come on, Glim.” Adora reasons on her girlfriend’s behalf. “She cut it off that one time.”

“That *one time*!” Glimmer repeats shrilly. “We are inside the castle, why am I the only one who-“

“Sorry!” Scorpia interrupts. “Sorry to interrupt, um, but what’s happening right now? Wildcat, are you alright? Did someone do something to you? Entrapta!”

“Here!” Her eyes snap up from her tablet and she looks around with wild eyes.

“We should take Emily and track down whoever-“

“Scorpia!” Catra cuts her off sharply. “Sorry, just…chill, okay? I’m fine. It’s…good news. I think?” She turns to Adora who grins brightly back with an enthusiastic nod.

She turns to the rest of the group. “It’s like…*pretty* cool.”

“Yeah, I’d love to show everyone.” Catra makes hard eye contact with the queen while announcing this.

Glimmer huffs. “If there is *any* damage to my Castle, Catra, so help me…”

“Chill, Glitter, it’ll be fine.” She turns back to her friends. “So, obviously, Princess Saz was the Magicat queen around the same time as Mara was She Ra. She tried to stop the heart by destroying the Red Jasper, her runestone. It’s how they *chose* their queens, so after it was destroyed, and her eventual disappearance, she recommended the Magicats form a democracy.

“So, they did and-and they still exist. They’re mostly nomadic now but there’s a tunnel system in the Crimson Waste where some of them still live.” There’s a varied reaction around the table and Catra pauses while everyone gets there speculation out. She’s suddenly nervous to reveal this new truth. She barrels on anyhow. “Ahem, the Red Jasper…we found it.”

Perfuma gasps, already emotional. “Oh no, is it horribly broken?”

Catra breathes deeply and looks to Adora. She takes her partner’s hand and squeezes tightly in a silent reassurance. “It was.”

“Was?” Mermista leans forward a touch, just slightly less ambivalent than usual.

“Was.” Catra confirms. “Um, it needed connection with the current Magicat Princess. To uh, repair itself.”

Mermista leans forward further. “*And?*” In fact, now everyone is leaning toward Catra in their seats, waiting with bated breath.

"And…it's repaired now." She's dragging it out, she'll claim for all time that it's to get more of a reaction but Adora knows better. She smirks at the nerves in Catra's voice.

"*Ugh!*" Mermista groans, flopping back into her chair. Seahawk turns to fuss over her, much to her chagrin, but Catra retains everyone else's full attention.

"Wildcat! We're on the edge of our seat! Oh, this is so exciting! Who are they?" Scorpia's about to launch herself across the damn table at this point.

"Well…" With a last nervous look at Adora, Catra snaps her fingers. The move brings a small flame to life, hovering over her fingertips. And then pandemonium erupts.

Scorpia just bursts into emotional tears. Most of the other princesses start peppering Catra with questions, drowning each other out in their excitement. And then Mermista's voice cuts through.

"Okay…is that like, it?" Silence.

Catra flames go out and she smirks across the table. Seahawk cuts her off. "*Is that it?* My dearest Mermista, this is a revelation! Say now, Catra, there's a mighty fine adventure in store and I think you may be just the lady to help-"

"No." She answers flatly. Then she turns to Mermista and resumes her smirk. "To your question too. Sparkles just shared with me some very enlightening information earlier. Did you all know that *flames spread*?"

Glimmer huffs loudly. "What were you gonna do, Catra? Start flinging around your dang fire whip in here? There's paper *everywhere*!" She flings an arm out to indicate the various papers and reports everyone has spread in front of them.

"I'm sorry," Mermista drones. "but did you just say fire whip?"

"*Oooh!*" Scorpia laughs heartily. "Wow, so now you're just all, fire *whip*!" She flings her arm in a whip like motion Catra can't help but roll her eyes at.

"No, Scorp, I still don't say whip when I whip. That's stupid."

"Aw, but it's a fire whip! You gotta have a catchphrase. Something cool like…uh…*whip!*"

Catra rolls her eyes again. "Anyway. So that's what we found."

"Wait a second…" Frosta stands from her chair and points a finger at Catra. "That makes you a princess! …Doesn't it?" She looks around the table for confirmation, only to be met with expressions varying from gob smacked to infuriatingly smug.

"Well deduced there, squirt." Frosta turns to frown at Catra.

"I'm not a child!"

"Uh…" Catra turns like she's seeking reinforcement from the others. She isn't really, and no one wants to get in the middle of this anyway. "Hate to disagree but…"

"Okay!" Adora interrupts before Frosta can really get going. "Yes, Catra," She clearly can't help but smirk. "is a princess too. She won't need to govern Halfmoon, but her connection to the runestone is like, super important."

"Super important how?" Perfuma asks delicately, looking between Adora and Catra.

"Pft, I dunno." Catra answers. "There was this like, prophet or whatever when we got there. She said the Red Jasper needs to maintain a connection to thrive or something. So, it's me and when I croak it'll be someone else."

"Well, that's not the entire story." Glimmer corrects with an evil grin. Catra narrows her eyes at her.

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“Remember, ‘*your cup runneth over’*, you have to share.” She sing songs at Catra.

“Wait, like you and your-uh…like um, Queen Angella?” Scorpia asks.

Catra’s eyes go wide. “No!” Every head in the room snaps in her direction, Adora’s eyes sparkle with mirth-a question buried in them. “I-I mean, not like some kid, if that’s what you’re asking! Obviously. I don’t have a kid so, duh. But someone, yeah. Uh, maybe She Ra! Percival wouldn’t say. Doesn’t matter. Oh look, is that the time? Melog, shall we?”

Leaving their friends at a total loss behind them, Catra and Melog make a hasty exit. She heads directly to her tower to hide. Adora doesn’t wait long to find her there.

When they hear the door creak open, Melog spikes. Little and afraid they hide behind Catra’s bent knees and their mane goes red. Catra looks up, then down again to stroke it gently. “It’s okay, it’s just Adora.” They relax at that and resume their previous position, curled right up beside Catra.

“So…” Adora starts as she sits. “That went…well.”

Catra snorts. “Just say what you’re thinking, Princess. I’m not gonna drag it out of you.”

“Okay, what the hell was that?”

Catra sets her expression into something stony. “What was what?”

“*That!*” Adora gestures vaguely in the direction they’d both come from.

“Dunno what you’re talking about.” Catra lies, keeping her tone aloof.

Adora just scoffs at her, far from fooled. “Yeah, okay.” Then she sighs heavily and forces eye contact. “Catra, do you not want…”

Catra huffs at being forced to supply the rest of her question. With a roll of her eyes she clarifies, “What, kids?”

“Well, yeah.”

“Do *you*?”

Adora shrugs, her face uncertain. “I’m not totally sure. It’s… something I’ve thought about. Glimmer and Bow have been talking about maybe starting to try.”

“I’m-I don’t know, Adora. What the hell do either of us know about being parents anyhow?” Catra snuggles more tightly to Melog’s side and they let out a soft, comforting sound.

“Okay, maybe not that much. We definitely know what *not* to do.” She laughs tightly, an attempt at humor.

Catra gives it to her, chortling lightly. “Yeah, I guess…I’ve never really been around kids though. Not since *we* were kids anyway. They’re kind of…weird.”

“Yeah,” Adora laughs. “but so are you.”

Catra makes an indignant nose and pounces on her. “Shut up!”

They get into a tussle, wrestling around on the floor until Adora finally gets Catra pinned. She feels all the fight drain out of her. “Adora?”

Her grip slackens but she makes no move to climb off. “What’s up, babe?”

“Do you…do you think that’s what she meant? Percival. A-about sharing the runestone?”

Adora sags and, at the question, she does finally move to climb off her girlfriend. She sits next to her and watches Catra sit up. "I don't know. Maybe."

"Does that mean-I guess, do we even have a choice? Like is it just already decided? We're gonna have a-*that*?"

Adora breaks down into hopeless giggling. "A *that*?" She repeats between little snorts. "You mean a baby?"

Catra growls at her and Melog shifts to watch them more closely. "I'm serious!"

Adora sobers, mostly, wiping tears of mirth from the corners of her eyes. She takes Catra's hands in her and hold her in a stare. "Sorry, you're right. To answer your question; *no*, of course not. It's totally our decision Catra, no one else gets a say."

"But you want one." It's sort of a question, but not really.

Adora bites her lip, considering Catra's words. "I…I think so, yeah. I'm okay if we don't though. You're all I need."

Catra turns away, feeling far too vulnerable, and wipes at her eyes. She turns back to say. "Yeah, Princess. You're all I need too."

Adora smiles, the look so soft Catra aches. "Cool. Well…now that's settled, you wanna go show off a little? I barely made it out of there, everyone's dying to know what you can do."

Catra smirks, more than a little cocky. "Yeah, okay. Let's go show these losers what's what."

Adora snorts but she and Melog dutifully follow her as she exits the tower and makes her way outside.

Everyone wants a chance to spar with the fancy new princess. It's really annoying, honestly. Catra's sweating trying to keep up, her powers are instinctive for the most part, but she still has some room for improvement. Which is, frankly, also really annoying.

It's not *so* bad. Half the fucking princesses are terrified of fire. Perfuma will barely get close enough to her to spar and Catra's easily able to melt away all of Frosta's defenses. Even *Seahawk* wants to have a go. Of course, the minute they start he's calling for Mermista and hiding behind a rock, so. That session didn't last long either.

Mermista, on the other hand, makes for a more interesting challenge. Their powers are effectively exact opposites. Once Catra figures out how to deflect the water and effectively *boil* it though, things get even more interesting. Scorpia's a contender too, but too terrified of hurting her best friend to put up much of a fight.

Eventually, all the princess return to their *own* kingdoms, leaving Catra with her favorite sparring partner. Well, leaving her with She Ra. It's still the same old Adora in there though, and she leaves all the same openings for Catra to exploit. Plus, with those fancy healing powers Catra doesn't feel *too* terrible when she accidentally burns her.

Okay, she feels kind of awful. The few times it happens though, Adora is quick to assure her that's what all this is for. Practicing and gaining full control. The one time she gets Glimmer she is far less patient. Pouting and huffing while She Ra heals her. Catra doesn't feel so bad about that one.

Three weeks after they return home from the Waste, something entirely new happens. Just when Catra thought her life couldn't get an weirder. Catra and Adora are sparring outside, just past the royal gardens, and Adora is being infuriating.

"Aw, c'mon, Catra! I thought you were getting better." Adora taunts her as she leaps over Catra's flames once again. Catra

growls in annoyance and frustration.

"Shut up, dummy. I'm just going easy on you; I'd hate for you to get burnt again."

"Aw," Adora coos as she jumps high over the arch of fire *again*. "You like me or something?"

"Gross! I do *not* like you!" Catra whips her hand out again, frustrated when literally nothing happens. She growls loudly and stomps her foot into the ground. And then she's leaping back and falling on her butt with a shriek. "*What the hell?*"

"Uh…" Adora creeps forward, careful to keep her distance from the small puddle of *lava* Catra just created. She looks up to her girlfriend, across the small crater. "That's new."

"No shit, dummy."

"Can you…get rid of it? Glimmer's not gonna be a fan if she sees it."

Catra rolls her eyes but scoots just a touch closer. She tries like, vibing with the energies or whatever it was Perfuma'd been going on about. Without thought, her hand makes a small swooping motion and then the pushes it down.

She and Adora blink at the small, rocky crater left behind. "Well." Adora comments. "Guess we know how Princess Saz made those tunnels."

Catra blinks down at the crater, then up at her girlfriend. And then she just *laughs*. "Why is everything with you so *weird*?"

Adora laughs too and shrugs. "I dunno, Princess. You tell me."

Catra flops back with a groan, in continual disbelief that this is her *life* now. But it is, and if she's honest? She's grateful every day for that fact. So, she gets up, and she tries again.

Chapter End Notes

Hiii! Hi hi hi!!
Thanks to everyone who's waited patiently for this update while I got distracted by a billion other things! I know it took like, two months which is basically forever. I promise the epilogue will be much quicker! I've had that written about 75% of the way while I got stuck on this bit, so I'd say I'll probably have it out in a matter of days!

I'm still toying with the idea of a sequel but it's firmly on the back burner for now. I've got a my attention on a couple other WIPs for the time being.

Thanks for reading and to everyone who has commented, and inquired about the resolution to this story!!

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Adora, *come on*, how many times are you gonna check the diaper bag?"

"I just feel like we're forgetting something!"

"Then we'll ask Swift Wind to come back and get it for us. He loves Finn more than we do, I'm sure he won't mind." Catra watches her wife repack the contents of Finn's diaper bag for the fifth time in two hours. At Catra words she gasps and moves to the swing Finn bounces in happily to cover their ears. They make a discontented noise and flicks their ears irritably when Adora moves her hands away again.

"*Excuse me*, I hardly think that's accurate Catra! And anyway, I'd have thought you'd be more excited. They were too little to go last year, *yes you were you tiny little thing*, this is a big deal." She turns away from tickling at their child and puts a hand on her hip when she faces Catra.

"Yeah, it is. Which is why I'd prefer we weren't a million years late getting there."

"Pfft, we're fine."

"Adora! We were supposed to be leaving twenty minutes ago!"

"Yeah, but you also planned for us to get there super early. Plus, you forgot to factor in Finn's nap."

"Oh please, they could fall asleep on Swift Wind's back while he does loop-de-loops. They'll get their nap in just fine."

"Whatever you say, but if they're cranky later because of poor quality sleep I'm not gonna be the one on crybaby duty." She turns back to the baby. "*No, I'm not, am I? Because that's gonna be your stinky momma*."

"Adora! Please, I just want us to get on the road."

Adora turns and surveys her wife. She rolls her eyes fondly and huffs. "Alright, alright. You're right that should be ever-oh no." Her face freezes in horror and Catra smirks, already knowing what coming. "Okay, don't be mad; I may have been so focused on making sure Finn was ready I forgot to pack a bag. I'll be so quick, shoot! I can't believe- "

"Yeah, I don't know why you find that so hard to believe, because I sure can. I already have your bag ready."

"You do?" Adora brightens.

"Yeah dummy, I'm not missing the Pilgrimage because you have worse baby brain than I did, even while I was pregnant."

Adora drifts over and drops a soft kiss on her cheek. "You're sweet."

"Yeah, yeah. Grab the kid and let's *go*." Despite her instructions Catra scoops Finn up herself and throws the diaper bag over her shoulder. "Your mother is a ridiculous person Finn; pray you get *my* wit and wisdom."

"I'd call you out for being rude-which to be clear, you are-but I already pray for that every day, so."

"Wow, you're such a kiss ass. You like me or something?"

"I swear to Mara, Catra; if our child's first word is 'ass' or something equally not cute I'm unleashing She Ra on you."

"Alright, *enough* flirting with me, Princess. Finn and I are leaving now, are you coming?"

“Yeah, whatever, Princess Catra, let move.”

As they scramble out the door Catra murmurs in Finns ear, “How do you feel about having just *one* mommy Finn?”

“*I heard that!*”

“That was entirely the point so.”

Despite Catra’s fussing, or maybe because of it, they reach Halfmoon well before the ceremony starts. Percival and Catra will kick things off with a few words and then the Magicats will meditate beneath the sun as it reaches its highest point in the sky.

Afterwards there will be a huge party. It always goes well past nightfall, into the early hours of the morning. The first year it had been…a lot. It still is of course but coming prepared for the action always helps. All the princesses of Etheria will be there to pay tribute and participate, as has been tradition since Catra’s second year coming.

Many of them will stay till dawn living it up. Of course, Scorpia and Perfuma, Bow and Glimmer, and Catra and Adora will all be retiring much earlier. Babies are exhausting. Maybe next year they’ll have enough energy left that it’ll be worth hiring a babysitter. That is, if Adora’s ready to be away from Finn for more than ten seconds at a time by that point.

The instant they walk into the Magicat tunnels, Finn is transfixed. With their eyes glued to the Red Jasper they begin to babble and coo on and on.

“Someone has a lot to say.” Adora laughs with an eyebrow raised at the baby in Catra’s arms. “*Don’t ya Finny? Yes! You just have so much to say.*”

Catra rolls her eyes fondly. “*How* old until you outgrow the baby talk?”

Adora scoffs, smile fixed in place. She's heard this before. "Shut up! They like it. *Don't*-"

Catra cuts off her wife, and their child's adorable giggling. "Okay, enough. Finn, you wanna go see the runestone?" They shriek gleefully and, with a small wince at the piercing sound, Catra takes that as a yes. She straps Finn to her chest and climbs the stone's dais with ease.

They reach the top and both Mother and child stare up in wonder, the power radiating through them. Of course, something feels different this time, as Catra had a feeling it might. It's strange though, she thought sharing the Red Jasper's power would make it feel…less somehow. Like for every bit shared with Finn, she would have that much less.

It's the opposite from the truth as it turns out. Catra's power feels like it increases exponentially, and she can feel *Finn* in every bit of it. It's…she laughs to herself; it's magic. Finn continues to stare up at the stone, but Catra looks down toward Adora. She's shielding her eyes and staring up at them.

When she sees Catra looking she gives her a big smile and a thumbs up. Catra can't help but laugh, her wife is such a dork. She loves her so much, and their child. She looks up at the Red Jasper once more. Somehow it too feels like part of her family.

It's nothing she ever saw for herself when she was younger. The idea of her and Adora being princess, with a *child* no less, would likely have repulsed her. Of course, the Adora of it all…she barely dared hope for it, wished for it only silently and in secret. And now…well all of the *weird* is certainly worth all of the *perfect*, that's for damn sure.

It dawns on her, not for the first time but no less a revelation; Catra is happy. And Catra is *loved*. She reaches up to brush her fingers against the bottom of the runestone. A babbling Finn reaches out in the same direction and she laughs at their cuteness, grabbing their little hand in her fingers.

Together, more powerful than ever, they make their way down to Adora and they get this party started.

Chapter End Notes

It took longer than I ever anticipated, but that's a wrap folks! This was a chill exercise and I might circle back to this universe. For now though, I'm working on my college AU and finally circling back to my magical realism bullshit. So that'll be a thing one of these days.

Also, Finn's a gemini. My story, my rules, it's cannon now, Idk what to tell you. (Jk but also...)

Thanks for reading!! It's always very much appreciated :)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!